

DIGAMBAR HARIBANS GIRI
POINTING AT HEAVEN

His dreadlocks, cascading in wild, tangled coils, seem long enough to reach Jamaica, but space isn't the frontier for Haribans Giri. He has long surrendered to time: his upraised left hand frozen in mid-air for five years, the fingers curled and rigid, the nails a long-running mystery with strange twists, that *jata* uncut for 15 of his 57 years. All signs of an ascetic life given over to modes of self-mortification. A sanyasi at 12, Haribans had by 24 endured the harsh initiatory rites of the Naga brotherhood of renunciates. Ordained into the Atal Akhara, his *atal yoga*—unstinting penance—once entailed standing. Never sitting or lying down, even sleeping suspended in a cloth swing, feet untouched by rest. He stood thus for 12 years, then took up a new challenge—never to lower his left hand. "At first, the pain was unbearable. The arm swelled, the muscles screamed. But the body learns," he intones.